

Adventures and fairy tales



REGRET AND REUNION

This photograph from a 1966 production of *A Winter's Tale* shows Polixenes with King Leontes. The King imagines that Polixenes is having an affair with his wife and locks her away. The queen fakes her own death, filling Leontes with grief and regret, and the couple are ultimately reunited.

SHIPWRECK SPELL

The Tempest is about a magician called Prospero, the rightful Duke of Milan. He is overthrown by his brother and goes to live on an island with his daughter, his fairy helper Ariel, and a band of other spirits. He uses magic to cause a shipwreck that brings his enemies to the island for punishment.



Illustration for
The Tempest by
Robert Dudley, 1856

Prospero's spirits bring
a banquet to the
shipwrecked seafarers

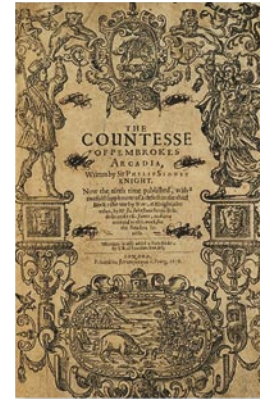


Illustration for
Cymbeline by
Robert Dudley, 1856

"... I come
To answer thy best
pleasure; be't to fly,
To swim, to dive
into the fire, to ride
On the curled clouds ..."

WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE
Ariel in *The Tempest*

FULL OF SURPRISES
In the play *Cymbeline*, Posthumus and Imogen, the husband and wife hero and heroine, are forced to part when Posthumus is banished. The play follows their fortunes while they are apart. *Cymbeline* has more plot twists than any other Shakespearean play, with eight surprises in a row in the final scene.



NOVEL IDEA

Shakespeare found the basic ingredients for his romances in prose works like Sir Philip Sydney's *Arcadia* (1593). This long tale, a forerunner of the novel, follows the adventures of two disguised princes in their search for love.



ROMANTIC INFLUENCE

Shakespeare was also influenced by two playwrights, Francis Beaumont and John Fletcher, who had been writing stage romances since 1607. Fletcher later worked with Shakespeare on his last three plays, and took over from him as the main playwright for the King's Men.